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# Inside CA's crackdown on homelessness: More arrests, same outcomes

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A year after the U.S. Supreme Court granted cities more authority to clear homeless encampments, how much has California's homelessness crisis changed?

As CalMatters' Marisa Kendall explains — along with Lisa Halverstadt from Voice of San Diego and Aaron Schrank from LAist — the landmark Grants Pass v. Johnson ruling allowing local authorities to arrest unhoused people for sleeping in public spaces has empowered cities across California to ramp up efforts to sweep encampments, or pass more punitive anti-camping rules.

In Los Angeles for example, the police department made 68% more camping arrests in the second half of 2024 (after the court ruling), compared to the first. But last March, the Los Angeles Homeless Services Agency found that while 94% of people targeted under the camping ordinance wanted shelter, only 17% were able to secure it.

That includes Deadra Walicki, a 51-year-old unhoused person living near Van Nuys Boulevard in L.A.'s San Fernando Valley. In a span of 16 months — from August 2023 through December 2024 — the LAPD cited Walicki 34 times for illegal camping.

Walicki, for the most part, ignores the citations because she has neither the money to pay the fines nor a phone to contact her case manager. She lives in an encampment with her male partner, and says she wants both of them to be admitted into separate gender-segregated shelters at the same time. This, however, hasn't happened yet.

* Walicki: "The cops come here Monday through Friday and give tickets for being in the zone of the shelter. It's whatever they want to do."

L.A. isn't the only city where citations for camping and other homelessness-related offenses soared shortly after Grants Pass. After filing more than 100 public records requests, Marisa found that in San Francisco, arrests and citations increased 500%, and in San Diego and Sacramento, arrests and citations doubled and tripled, respectively.

Read more about what it's like to live on the streets after Grants Pass and how cities are enforcing anti-camping ordinances.

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California's housing crisis, explained: CalMatters has detailed looks at why housing is so expensive in California and why homelessness is so persistent. We also have a lesson-plan-ready version of these explainers and other information — especially made for teachers, libraries and community groups — as part of the CalMatters for Learning initiative, with Spanish translations.

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Other Stories You Should Know

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Cutting research funds, cutting forests

Let's dive into some federal news affecting California:

* Restoring research funding: On Monday federal judges issued rulings to restore hundreds of science research grants, including about 430 in California, which President Donald Trump's administration initially canceled earlier this year as part of an effort to cut funding for programs related to diversity, equity and inclusion. The frozen funds affected research related to, among other things: dementia, vaccines and health disparities among women and the LGBTQ+ community. The administration has filed appeals for some of the rulings, and it remains unclear when the money will be restored. Read more from CalMatters' Mikhail Zinshteyn.

* Removing forest protections: The Trump administration said it plans to rescind a rule developed under the Clinton administration that could result in the lifting of bans on logging and road construction within parts of national forests, including more than 4 million acres throughout California. The U.S. Secretary of Agriculture said this would prevent fires, but some experts argue that timber harvesting may actually promote more flammable fuels in forests. Read more from CalMatters' Rachel Becker.

Banning ultra-processed food from school meals?

The state Senate is considering a bill that would get rid of food containing chemical additives — such as stabilizers, coloring and flavoring agents — in school meals by 2035.

As CalMatters' Kristen Hwang explains, the proposal by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel has strong bipartisan support, and aligns with both Gov. Gavin Newsom's executive order to limit the harms of ultra-processed foods, and the federal administration's "Make America Healthy Again" campaign.

* Gabriel, an Encino Democrat: "Even though Republicans and Democrats can't agree on much, one of the things they can agree on is this common sense notion that we should be protecting our kids."

But a coalition of food and beverage manufacturers and other business groups oppose the measure, arguing that it makes consumers inaccurately perceive all ultra-processed food as unsafe. Pizza, for example, has ingredients such as dough conditioners and stabilizers to keep them shelf stable.

* Dennis Albiani, a coalition spokesperson and president of Capitol Advocates lobbying firm: "Healthy products are going to be pulled in and labeled as ultra-processed, which in the lexicon of America means dangerous and unhealthy."

Read more here.

And lastly: Not enough CA court reporters

California's court reporters shortage makes it nearly impossible for some litigants to appeal their cases. While some legal aid groups want to overturn a state ban on court recordings, one powerful union is pushing a bill that critics say would make it even harder to record inside a courtroom. Read more from CalMatters' Ryan Sabalow.

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California Voices

CalMatters columnist Dan Walters: Years after the height of the pandemic, two state programs — California's unemployment insurance program and workers' compensation — are still struggling to provide safety nets for residents.

Other things worth your time:

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US citizen arrested during LA ICE raid in what family describes as 'kidnapping' // The Guardian

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Judge rules CA FAIR Plan used illegal policy for fire claims // The Sacramento Bee

A second state worker union secures delay to Newsom's return-to-office order // The Sacramento Bee

CA colleges worry about lawsuit challenging funding for campuses with many Hispanic students // EdSource

Malaysia will stop accepting US plastic waste, creating a dilemma for CA // Los Angeles Times

Farmworkers union says ICE raids continue in Central CA despite Trump's pledge // The Fresno Bee

Justice Department sues Orange County registrar of voters over non-citizen voting records // The Orange County Register

Proposal to mandate $25 minimum wage for San Diego tourism workers moves forward // The San Diego Union-Tribune

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